TECHNICAL COMMUNICATION (AASL0401): 2nd SESSIONAL CHEAT SHEET

Priority: ★★★ must-do (asked most) · ★★ important · ★ quick read · highlight = keyword

UNIT 2: TECHNICAL WRITING I (after Letter writing)

Meetings: the 3 aspects ★★

A meeting always has a purpose (give information, take decisions). A good meeting needs careful preparation. The **3 important aspects of a meeting** are **Notice → Agenda → Minutes**: before, during, after.
4 Ws of a successful meeting: **Why, Who, Where, When**.

1. NOTICE ★★★

Definition: A notice is **written or printed information**, usually **displayed publicly**, that conveys the **same message to many people** at once. For a meeting, it is the information sent to all participants telling them a meeting is being called (*convened*).

Purpose: to **inform, advertise, instruct, warn**. Shown at railway stations, bus stands, hospitals, colleges, govt. offices. Sent by printed circular, e-mail or phone.

Qualities of a good notice

- **Accurate, clear, concise, decisive**
- Correct, unambiguous, polite language; short words and sentences
- Attractive layout; reader-friendly; readable from a distance

A notice must contain

- **Title / heading** ("NOTICE"), name of organisation
- **Date of issue**
- Event information + **type of meeting** (committee, AGM…)
- **Date, time, venue** of the event
- **Purpose** (agenda) of the meeting
- **Name + designation + signature** of the issuer
- Copies to (**Cc**) at the bottom left/right

Drafting tips: use organisation's **letterhead**; send in **reasonable time (generally 2 weeks before)**; put it in a box.

```
ABC INSTITUTE, GREATER NOIDA
NOTICE
13 Oct 2026
BLOOD DONATION CAMP
All members are informed that a blood donation
camp will be held on 20 Oct 2026, 10 am–4 pm,
at the Main Auditorium. Interested students
may
register with the undersigned by 17 Oct.
Sd/-  Rahul Verma, Secretary, NSS Club
Cc: Director, HoDs
```

2. AGENDA ★★★

Definition: An agenda is the **official list of items (topics) to be discussed or dealt with at a meeting**, arranged in order. From Latin **agendum = "a thing to be done"**. It outlines the business of a *forthcoming* meeting and is usually **sent along with the notice**.

Who prepares: the **Secretary**, in consultation with the **Chairperson**; **signed by the Secretary**; distributed **before** the meeting. Written in **future tense**.

Format / order of items

1. **First item always:** Confirmation of minutes of the **previous meeting**
2. Matters arising from those minutes (status of pending work)
3. Main issues, in **order of priority**
4. Any other business (with Chair's permission)
5. **Last item:** Date of the **next meeting**

Should include: location, date, timing, topics + short description, time given to each topic, names of members.

Language: **Brevity, Clarity, Informativeness, Relevance**.

Writing steps: list attendees → list topics → note purpose of each (information / brainstorming / decision) → drop irrelevant items → link people to topics → check against meeting objectives.

Advantages: confirms date/time/place; **directs the course** of meeting; **prevents digressions**; gives members time to prepare opinions; helps reach **consensus**. Without it a meeting is a waste of time.

3. MINUTES OF MEETING ★★★

Definition: Minutes are the **official written record** of the **discussions held and decisions/resolutions taken** at a meeting, in **chronological order**. They are concise and written **after the meeting in past tense**.

Written by the Secretary; **signed by Secretary + Chairperson** (after approval by members).

Minutes must give

1. Name of organisation/unit
2. Day, date, time, place
3. Serial no. (e.g., "33rd meeting of…")
4. Names of **Chairperson & Secretary**
5. Members **present** and **absentees** (leave of absence)
6. Record of each item: discussion + **decision taken** + action by whom
7. Signatures

Importance: **aid to memory**; **basis for action**; informs **absent members**; legal/official record.

Agenda vs Minutes ★★★

Agenda	Minutes
List of topics **to be** discussed	Record of what **was** discussed + decided
Prepared **before** the meeting	Prepared **after** the meeting
Future tense	**Past** tense
Signed by Secretary	Signed by Secretary + Chairperson
Guides the meeting	Basis for future action / proof

4. JOB APPLICATION (Cover Letter) ★★★

Definition: A job application letter (also called a **cover letter**) is a formal letter sent **with the résumé**. The résumé lists your history; the letter **explains why you are qualified and should be called for an interview**. It sets the **tone** of the résumé.

Basic structure (3 parts): **Introduction** (post applied for + where you saw the advert) → **Details** (qualifications, experience, how you meet their needs; the most important part) → **Conclusion** (thank them, **request an interview**, follow-up info).

Elements

- **Heading:** your + employer's contact details, date
- **Subject:** Application for the post of …
- **Salutation:** Dear Mr./Ms. + last name / Dear Sir/Madam
- **Body:** 3 paragraphs above
- **Complimentary close:** Yours sincerely / Sincerely
- **Signature** + typed name; **Enclosure:** Résumé

Exam tip: "Job application" = cover letter + résumé (2 parts).

5. CV vs RÉSUMÉ ★★★

Résumé (French word = **"summary"**): a short (1 page, max 2) **tool to market your skills**, experience, education and achievements, **tailored to one job**. Used for any job. Starts with Summary of Qualifications → Areas of strength (keywords) → Experience in reverse order.

CV / Curriculum Vitae (Latin = **"course of life"**): a **long, detailed** record of your **entire academic and professional history**, including degrees, publications, research, affiliations. Used for **academic, scientific, research** posts (and generally in Europe/Asia).

	Résumé	CV
Origin	French, "summary"	Latin, "course of life"
Length	1 (max 2) pages	2+ pages, variable
Focus	Skills for a specific job	Full academic record
Used for	Any job / industry	Academic, research, teaching
Nature	Customised per job	Static, complete

Résumé formats/types ★★

Reverse Chronological	Functional (Skills-based)
Arranged by **dates**, latest first; shows **career progression**; **employers prefer it**	Arranged under **skill headings**; highlights abilities
+ Easy to follow job history; past employer names stand out; good when staying in **same field**	+ Good for a **new goal/career change**; skills stand out
− Hard to highlight what you do best	− Unclear what you did in which job; past companies hidden

(Third type: **Combination**. "Portfolio" is NOT a résumé format.)

Résumé contents (in order) ★★★

1. **Heading:** full name, complete address, phone (C/H/W), professional e-mail (not "rambocecil@…")
2. **Objective / Profile summary** (optional): **specific & concise**.
   ✔ *"An internship at Computer Sciences Corporation in computer programming."*
   ✘ *"An internship utilizing my skills and training."*
3. **Education:** **reverse chronology**; institution, location, year, degree, major/minor, CGPA, awards, study abroad
4. **Related coursework** (optional): when lacking experience
5. **Experience:** jobs, internships, volunteer, projects; can split into Related / Additional
6. **Skills:** computer (languages: C++, Java; apps; OS: Unix/Linux) + languages with proficiency
7. **Honours, activities, research, professional affiliations**
8. Achievements, co-/extra-curricular, strengths, hobbies, **references**, personal details

✘ Never include **religious affiliation**.

Résumé style & writing tips ★★

- Font **10–12 pt**, Times New Roman/Arial; **½"–1" margins**; balance white space
- Bold/CAPS for headings; lines between sections; bullets with **action verbs**; **quantify** results
- White/light paper; same paper for résumé, cover letter, references
- Customise for each job; accentuate the positive; employers glance only **10–20 seconds**
- Always send a cover letter; paper clip, don't staple

3 C's of résumé: **Clarity** (clear, concise presentation), **Consistency** (don't mix categories/dates), **Conciseness** (summarise, highlight).

ATS-friendly résumé ★

ATS = Applicant Tracking Software/System: software that **scans résumés for keywords** before a human sees them. Use simple formatting (no tables/graphics), **keywords from the job description**, standard fonts (Arial/Calibri), bullet points, standard headings (Work Experience, Education, Skills).

UNIT 3: TECHNICAL WRITING II (complete)

7 C's of Effective Communication ★★★

1. **Completeness**: gives **all information** the audience needs; leaves no questions.
2. **Conciseness**: least possible words without losing meaning ("Brevity is the soul of wit"); no unnecessary details.
3. **Consideration**: "**stepping into the shoes of others**": the **"You" attitude**; knowing reader's background, mindset, education.
4. **Clarity**: one specific goal at a time; familiar words, **avoid jargon**.
5. **Concreteness**: **specific and particular**, not vague/general; exact facts and figures.
6. **Courtesy**: sincere, polite, judicious, enthusiastic; builds **goodwill**.
7. **Correctness**: correct grammar, format, content and facts.

REPORT: definition & purpose ★★★

Definition: From Latin **"reportare" = to carry back**. A report is a **formal, factual document**, based on **evidence**, written for a **specific audience to meet a specific need**. It presents facts about a situation/project/process, **analyses and interprets** them, draws **conclusions** and gives **recommendations**. It is a basic **management tool for decision-making**. Length: 1-page trip report to 250-page annual report; oral, written or electronic.

Purposes/significance: present data; record events; describe problems + suggest solutions; analyse a situation; give feedback/recommendations; standard reference for planning; easy circulation of information.

Characteristics of a good report ★★★

- **Precision**: clear purpose → unity and coherence
- **Factual details**: accurate, detailed facts
- **Relevance**: only relevant facts (irrelevant ones confuse)
- **Reader-oriented**: written keeping the reader in mind
- **Simple, unambiguous language**: clear, brief, grammatical
- **Special format**: cover, title page, contents, illustrations, appendices
- **Homogeneity**: deals with **one main topic**
- **Documentation**: sources acknowledged properly
- Also: **objectivity**, clarity, accuracy (**ambiguity is NOT** a feature)

Types of reports ★★★

Basis	Type	Meaning, e.g.
Function	Informational	Data **without analysis**: conference, seminar, trip report
	Analytical	Data **with analysis & interpretation**: project, market research report
Frequency	Routine	At **regular intervals**: daily production, monthly sales, annual
	Special	One specific situation: thesis, enquiry report, proposal
Form	Oral	Face to face: accident, sales, joining report
	Written	Project, progress, research report
Length	Formal	Long, elaborate: annual, project, technical
	Informal	Short: lab, daily, trip report

4 Formats of a report ★★★

Chosen by **nature, scope, length, function, audience**.

1. **Pre-printed form**: fill-in/tick form for **routine info** (daily production). Systematic, objective, saves time.
2. **Letter format**: short report to someone **outside** the organisation (external). Letter parts + headings, references.
3. **Memo format**: short report **within** the organisation (internal). To/From/Date/Subject + headings.
4. **Manuscript format**: **long, formal** reports (few to hundreds of pages), sections with headings. **Longest** format.

"Demi-official" is NOT a report format.

Structure of a FORMAL (long) report ★★★

A. Prefatory / Front matter

- **Title page**: title, submitted to, submitted by, date (report no., logo)
- **Preface** (optional, only in published reports): writer's personal intro: background, reasons, scope, highlights
- **Letter of transmittal**: **covering letter** stating purpose, scope, highlights
- **Acknowledgement**: "thank-you note" to contributors
- **Table of contents**: headings/sub-headings + page numbers
- **List of illustrations**: tables, graphs, figures
- **Abstract / Executive summary**: **gist** of key findings, conclusions, recommendations

B. Main body

- **Introduction**: background, aims, **scope & limitations**; proposes the problem
- **Methodology**: how data was collected (library, internet, interviews, surveys)
- **Discussion/Findings/Analysis**: **longest, main part**; organised data with headings
- **Conclusion**: summary of findings and their meaning
- **Recommendations**: suggested course of action, further work

C. Supplementary / Back matter

- **Appendices**: supporting material (questionnaires, charts) kept separate so body flows
- **References**: sources **cited** in text · **Bibliography**: sources consulted, **not cited** (alphabetical)
- **Glossary**: technical terms + meanings, alphabetical ("dictionary")
- **Index**: alphabetical topics with page nos.; for bulky reports

Abstract vs Executive Summary ★★

Abstract	Executive Summary
Essence	Summary
2–5% of report	5–10% of report
Specialist to specialist	For all readers (managers)
Qualitative	Qualitative + quantitative
No illustrations	May have illustrations

Short report ★★

½ to 2 pages, in **memo-like format**, to inform an authority on one matter for a decision. Parts: **Introduction → Discussion → Summary → Conclusions → Recommendations → Appendix**.

Steps of writing a report / research paper ★★

Analyse problem/purpose (Terms of Reference) → Scope → Audience analysis → Investigation (primary & secondary sources) → Organise → Outline → First draft → Revise, review, edit → Final draft

Project report & Thesis/Dissertation ★★★

Project report: a **completion report** written after finishing a project. Gives an account of its stages, and a systematic presentation and discussion of data collected and analysed. Internal or external.

Thesis/Dissertation: a **long research report** presenting original research (or data from sources), describing and analysing a **systematic investigation to add to knowledge** in a field. It covers what was known before, progress made, interpretation, and future scope.

Extra elements beyond a formal report: Background, Objectives, Literature Review, Materials & Equipment, Theory & Procedure.

Dissertation	Thesis
Short: 30–50 pages	Long: 200–250 pages
Limited problem	Problem of wide impact
Evaluated by guide (internal)	Internal + external examiner

TECHNICAL PROPOSAL ★★★

Definition: "Propose" = **"to put forward for consideration"**. A proposal is a **systematic, formal and persuasive** set of **recommendations to solve a problem**, written for a specific audience before a project begins. It **explains and justifies** what it proposes; it is the **first step** of a new project.

Uses: initiate new projects; fresh ideas; solve problems; promote innovative strategies; **win contracts**.

Importance: records of info, index of company growth, financial gain, promote research.

Types

- By subject: **Business/Sales** (external, to clients), **Research** (academic), **Technical**
- **Solicited**: written **in response to a request/invitation** (RFP, advert)
- **Unsolicited**: on writer's **own initiative**, no request
- **Internal** (within org.) / **External** (outside) · **Formal** (long) / **Informal** (short)

Writing steps: Planning (observe, methods) → Collect data (observation, interviews, questionnaire; internal records, library, online) → Write (rough draft → proofread → final).

Structure of a formal proposal ★★★

Prefatory: Title page · Letter of transmittal · **Draft contract** (**unique to proposals**: rough terms/rules of work) · Contents · List of illustrations · Executive summary/Abstract

Main body:

- **Introduction**: purpose, scope, limitations, problem, need, background; persuades
- **Technical section**: methods, plan of action, solutions available and why one is chosen
- **Managerial section**: sequence of activities (schedule); equipment, facilities, products; personnel qualifications
- **Cost estimate / Budget**: **mandatory**; materials, salaries, travel, etc.
- **Conclusion**: key benefits; final appeal

Supplementary: Appendices · References

Proposal vs Report ★★★

Proposal	Report
Future tense	**Past** tense
Beginning of project	**After completion**
Problem to be investigated: what, why, how	Results, findings, recommendations
Intro, Lit. review, Methodology	+ Results, Analysis, Conclusion, Recomm.
Has **finance + draft contract**	No finance/contract

TECHNICAL / SCIENTIFIC PAPER ★★

Definition: A written composition that **describes, discusses and analyses a systematic investigation** to add to knowledge in a specific field. It is **documented, objective** prose.

Features: adds to existing knowledge; transfers new findings to other researchers; systematic account of survey/research/field work; objective analysis of findings.

Characteristics: expository; highly stylised; objective, accurate, concise, unambiguous; uses **illustrations & jargon**; every claim backed by **evidence**.

Parts: Title → Author by-line → Abstract → Introduction → Methodology → Results → Discussion → Conclusion → Appendices → References. Title = long phrase with keywords: informative, specific.

Research methods: library research, electronic search, primary sources (surveys, questionnaires), experiments.

Type	Meaning
Journal article	Structured per the journal's **style guide**; formal peer review (higher value)
Conference paper	Text of paper **presented at a seminar/conference/workshop**; less academic value than journal
Review article	**Evaluates published work** on a topic; "how does it add to knowledge?"
Research article	Based on own research project/study

ETHICAL WRITING ★★

Definition: Writing that **clearly shows (through documentation) where source material is used**, uses **correct and authentic data**, and is **inclusive and respectful** of diversity. It avoids **plagiarism**, **bias**, and **exclusive language** (sexist, racist…), which increases the writer's **credibility**.

Citing rules: use latest style manual; cite **every borrowed idea**; cite **both paraphrases and direct quotes**.

PLAGIARISM ★★★

Definition: Presenting **someone else's work, ideas, words, images or results as your own without acknowledgement**. Merriam-Webster: "to steal and pass off the ideas or words of another as one's own"; **literary theft**.

Counts as plagiarism: submitting another's work; copying without credit; no quotation marks on a quote; wrong source info; changing words but keeping the sentence structure; copying so much it forms most of your work (even with credit).

Ways/types of plagiarising

- **Direct copying**: copy text/ideas as-is and label them yours
- **Paraphrasing** (without citation): change the language, keep the idea
- **Word switching**: change only a few words of the original
- **Self-plagiarism**: reuse your own published work as new

Law: Copyright Act, 1957

- **Sec 57**: author's **special/moral rights**: claim authorship; claim damages for distortion/mutilation
- **Sec 63**: 1st offence: **6 months–3 years jail** + **fine ₹50,000–₹2 lakh**
- **Sec 63(a)**: 2nd offence: **1–3 years** + **₹1–2 lakh**

Avoid by: citing, quoting, referencing; reliable sources; plagiarism checkers.

COPY EDITING ★★

Definition: Revising written material **before publication** to **improve readability** and make it free of errors of **punctuation, spelling, grammar, style** and fact.

Copy editor's duties: fix grammar (spelling, tense, subject-verb agreement); check facts & accuracy; make verbose copy **concise**; write headlines; delete opinions/**libellous** statements.

Types: Proofreading (grammatical accuracy, final check) · **Line editing** (content, style, language per line) · **Fact-checking** (accuracy, ideally before copy-edit) · **Rewriting** (reword/reorganise for flow).

5 C's of editing: Clarity, Cogency, Conventionality, Completeness, Concision.

Copy editing = whole improvement; proofreading = final surface-error check.

REFERENCING ★★★

Definition: A **standardised way of acknowledging the sources** (books, journals, websites, theses…) of ideas, data, images used in your writing, so the sources can be **identified and verified**.

Why: prevents plagiarism; credits author; credibility; readers can verify/follow up.

2 parts: Citation (in-text): brief pointer in the text, e.g. [1] or (Smith, 2009) · **Reference list**: full details at the end.

References vs Bibliography: references = only sources cited; bibliography = all sources consulted (alphabetical).

Styles: IEEE (engineering/CS), **APA** (social science; 7th ed.), **MLA** (humanities), Chicago, Harvard, Oxford. **MLA** = Modern Language Association; **APA** = American Psychological Association.

Missing info: n.a. (no author), n.p. (no publisher), n.d. (no date).

```
APA (Author, Year, Title, Publisher; alphabetical)
Raman, M. & Sharma, S. (2009). Professional
 communication. New Delhi: Oxford University
Press.
MLA (Name. Title. Place: Publisher, Year. Medium)
Raman, Meenakshi and Sharma, Sangeeta.
Professional
 Communication. New Delhi: OUP, 2009. Print.
IEEE (numbered [1] in order of appearance)
[1] S. Russell and P. Norvig, Artificial
Intelligence:
 A Modern Approach, 4th ed. Pearson, 2021.
[2] A. Sharma, "Title," IEEE Access, vol. 12,
 pp. 1234–1245, 2024.
```

Tools: Zotero, Mendeley, EndNote, Google Scholar, BibTeX. Figures/tables taken from others must cite source: "Fig. 1 … [6]".

Keynote speech ★

A speech with a **main underlying theme**, given at conventions/conferences to **motivate and inspire** (like persuasive speech). Use stories, humour, and repeat a core line to make the idea memorable.